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Department of Economics
Rosenbergstrasse 22
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Year of Birth: 1982.
Citizenship: Swiss.
Married, two children (2013, 2016).

Current Position

2023– Assistant Professor of Economics, University of St. Gallen (tenure-track).

Past Positions

2020–2022 Research Economist, Web 3.0 Technologies Foundation, Zug.
2019–2021 Postdoc, Department of Economics, University of St. Gallen.
2017–19 Postdoc, Department of Economics, University of Zurich.
2016–19 Laspeyres Fellow, Faculty of Business and Economics, University of Basel.
2016/17 Visiting Postdoc, Economics Department, Duke University, Durham, NC.
 Host: Curtis Taylor.
2014–16 Postdoc, Faculty of Business and Economics, University of Basel.
 SNSF-project: "Contests in Context and the Stability of Ownership".
 (Grant 146089. PI: Georg Nöldeke).

Teaching and Research Field

Primary: (Applied) microeconomic theory.

Secondary: Contract theory, dynamic contests, structural estimation of auctions, blockchain economics, incentives in cryptographic protocols.

Education

2014 Ph.D., University of Basel.
 Advisors: Yvan Lengwiler (1st), Georg Nöldeke (2nd).
2010 Swiss Program for Beginning Doctoral Students in Economics, Study Center Gerzensee.
2009 M.Sc. Business and Economics, University of Basel.
2007 B.A. Philosophy and Economics, University of Basel.

Short Academic Visits

Apr 2019 Duke University, Durham, NC (1 month). Host: Curtis Taylor.
Apr 2017 Chapman University, Orange, CA (3 weeks). Host: Dan Kovenock.
Sep 2015 Max-Planck Institute for Tax Law and Public Finance, Munich (1 week). Host: Kai Konrad.
Nov 2013 Max-Planck Institute for Tax Law and Public Finance, Munich (3 weeks). Host: Kai Konrad.

Scientific Publications

- [1] Häfner, S. and Taylor, C. (2023). Working for References. *American Economic Journal: Microeconomics*, 15(3):33–77. [\[link\]](#)
- [2] Häfner, S. (2023). Risk Aversion in Share Auctions: Estimating Import Rents from TRQs in Switzerland. *Quantitative Economics*, 14(2):419–470. [\[link\]](#)
- [3] Häfner, S. and Taylor, C. (2022). On Young Turks and Yes Men: Optimal Contracting for Advice. *The RAND Journal of Economics*, 53(1):63–94. [\[link\]](#)
- [4] Häfner, S. (2022). Eternal Peace in the Tug-of-War? *Economic Theory (Online First: 2020)*, 74:1570–1101. [\[link\]](#)
- [5] Häfner, S. and Nöldeke, G. (2022). Sorting in Iterated Incumbency Contests. *Economic Theory (Online First: 2019)*, 74:1103–1140. [\[link\]](#)
- [6] Häfner, S. (2018). Stable Biased Sampling. *Games and Economic Behavior*, 107:109–122. [\[link\]](#)
- [7] Häfner, S. (2017). A Tug-of-War Team Contest. *Games and Economic Behavior*, 104:372–391. [\[link\]](#)
- [8] Häfner, S. and Nöldeke, G. (2016). Payoff Shares in Two-Player Contests. *Games*, 7(3):25. [\[link\]](#)

Accepted Research Papers

- [1] *Price Gouging and the Monopoly Option* (with Curtis Taylor). First Version: October 2024. Latest Version: May 2026. [\[Link\]](#). Accepted for Publication in the Review of Economic Studies.

Completed Research Papers

- [1] *Mechanism Design with Information Leakage* (with Marek Pycia and Haoyuan Zeng). First Version: October 2025. [\[Link\]](#).
- [2] *The Candle Auction in the Field and in the Lab* (with Jonas Gehrlein and Jörg Oechssler). First Version: January 2025. Latest Version: February 2026. [\[Link\]](#).
- [3] *Front-Running in Ascending Auctions: The Case for a Random-Close Rule* (with Alistair Stewart). First Version: May 2021. Latest Version: August 2026. [\[Link\]](#).
- [4] *Optimal Compensation in Competitive Labor Markets with Heterogeneous Employers and Workers* (with Niklas Häusle, Winfried Koeniger, and Alexander Braun). First Version: November 2024. Latest Version: September 2025. [\[Link\]](#). Reject and Resubmit at JEBO.
- [5] *Shakeouts and Staggered Exits from an R&D Race with Moral Hazard*. First Version: March 2020. Latest Version: September 2023. [\[Link\]](#).

Current Teaching (University of St. Gallen)

- [1] *Blockchain Markets* (in English). M.Sc., Spring terms.
- [2] *Introduction to Market Design* (in English). B.Sc., Spring terms.
- [3] *Corporate Finance, Venture Capital, and Banking* (in English). M.Sc., Spring terms.
- [4] *Microeconomics for CS* (in English). B.Sc., Fall terms.
- [5] *Ph.D. Seminar* (in English). Ph.D., Fall terms (joint with Beatrix Eugster).

Past Teaching

- [1] *Topics in Economics* (in English). Ph.D., University of St. Gallen.
- [2] *Contract Theory* (in English). M.Sc. elective, University of Basel.

- [3] *Introduction to Game Theory* (in English). B.Sc., University of Zurich.
- [4] *Contest Theory with Applications* (in English). M.Sc. elective, University of Berne.
- [5] *Contest Theory* (in German). M.Sc. elective, University of Basel.
- [6] *Insurance Economics* (in German). B.Sc., University of Basel (joint with Georg Nöldeke).

Scientific Presentations

- 2026 VfS Industrial Economics Committee Meeting (Munich, Discussant), Workshop on Marketplaces (St. Gallen, invited), Swiss IO Day (Berne), CMID26 (York, invited), EARIE (Mannheim), University of Basel (invited), Cergy Paris (invited).
- 2025 VfS Industrial Economics Committee Meeting (Vienna, invited). Oligo Workshop (Cambridge), Swiss IO Day (Berne), SSES Congress (Zurich), EARIE (Valencia).
- 2024 Strategic Timing Problems in Economics and Mathematical Finance (Bielefeld, invited); The Future of Contest Theory (Berlin, invited); UC3M (invited); University of Konstanz (invited); Berkeley/Columbia/Duke/MIT/Northwestern IO Theory Conference (Duke University).
- 2023 IBEO Workshop Digital Economics (Alghero); EARIE (Rome).
- earlier 2022: University of St. Gallen. 2021: Annual Meeting of Swiss Society of Economics and Statistics (Zurich, online). 2020: Econometric Society World Meeting (Milan, online); Annual Meeting of Swiss Society of Economics and Statistics (Zurich, canceled); IIOC (Philadelphia, canceled). 2019: UECE Meetings (Lisbon); Swiss Competition Commission (Berne); Asian Meeting of the Econometric Society (Xiamen). 2018: Seventeenth Annual Berkeley/Columbia/Duke/ MIT/Northwestern IO Theory Conference (Cambridge, MA), EARIE (Athens), Swiss Theory Day (Berne); Swiss IO Day (Berne); Annual Meeting of Swiss Society of Economics and Statistics (St. Gallen). 2017: Bonn Junior Day, EARIE (Maastricht), ESEM (Lisbon), VfS-Jahrestagung (Wien), Chapman University. 2016: UNC (Chapel Hill); Duke; University of St. Gallen; Conference on the Current Frontiers in the Theory of Contest (Munich); Swiss Theory Day (Zurich); WZB (Berlin). 2015: Basel-Zurich Workshop in Micro Theory (Zurich); Annual Meeting of Swiss Society of Economics and Statistics (Basel); XVII. Tax Day (Munich). 2014: Basel-Zurich Workshop in Micro Theory (Zurich); 25th Stony Brook Game Theory Festival (Stony Brook). 2013: X. Tax Day (Munich); EPCM2013 (Zurich); Young Swiss Economists Meeting (Berne). 2011: Young Researchers Workshop on Contests and Tournaments (Berlin); Tournaments, Contests and Relative Performance Evaluation (Raleigh). 2010: APET2010 (Istanbul); Spring Meeting of Young Economists (Luxembourg); 3rd Ruhr Graduate Doctoral Conference (Bochum); Young Swiss Economists Meeting (Berne).

Refereeing

Review of Economic Studies, Theoretical Economics, RAND Journal of Economics, American Economic Journal: Microeconomics, Games and Economic Behavior, American Journal of Political Science, Economic Theory, Journal of Economics and Management Science, Social Choice and Welfare, The B.E. Journal of Theoretical Economics, Journal of Conflict Resolution, Journal of Mathematical Economics, Mathematical Social Sciences, Swiss Journal of Economics and Statistics, VfS Jahrestagung (2017).

Workshop Organization

- 2026 Annual Congress of the Swiss Society for Economics and Statistics, St. Gallen (co-organizer). HSG Fintech Summit, Zürich (co-organizer). Tokenomics, Singapore (program committee).

2024	St. Gallen Workshop on Dynamic Contracts and Learning (co-organizer).
2023	Tokenomics, Paris (program committee). Swiss Theory Day, University of St. Gallen (local organizer).
2022	Tokenomics, Paris (program committee).
2021	SSES Annual Meeting, Zurich (program committee).
2020	2nd St. Gallen IO Workshop (co-organizer). SSES Annual Meeting, Zurich (program committee).

Other Professional Activities

- [1] Member of the VfS Industrial Economics Committee (2025-).
- [2] Member of the Econ Ph.D. Program Committee (St. Gallen, 2026-).
- [3] Member of the Hiring Committee, Professor of Microeconomics, University of St. Gallen (2024-25).
- [4] Organization of the Research Seminar, School of Economics and Political Science, University of St. Gallen (2020–2021, 2024–).
- [5] Elected Member of the Faculty Assembly (Faculty of Business and Economics, Basel, 2016–19).

Outreach Activities

- [1] Submission in the Consultation Procedure on the Amendment of the Wine Ordinance (2026/25). Together with Prof. Yvan Lengwiler (University of Basel).
- [2] Presentation and Panel Discussant: Avenir Suisse (Zürich, 2025).
Topic: Competition or security of supply - an irresolvable conflict of objectives? (*Wettbewerb oder Versorgungssicherheit – ein unauflösbarer Zielkonflikt?*)
- [3] Executive Education: Intensive Course *Blockchain Finance* (Online, 2025).
Organized by the Institute of Insurance Economics (IVV-HSG). I taught Module 6: *Decentralized Finance*.
- [4] Panel Discussant: EPFL Blockchain Day (Lausanne, 2024).
Organized by the Blockchain Student Association of EPFL. The panel's topic was "The Role of Universities for the Crypto Industry."
- [5] Panel Discussant: Matching in Practice (Zurich, 2024).
Topic "Simplicity in Market Design." I talked about my experience as a research economist at Web3 Foundation, together with Marek Pycia and Sven Seuken.

External Funding

2026	Scientific Exchange Grant, SNSF. Grant IZSEZ0_241821. Funding for Annual Congress of the SSES. 4,800 CHF. (Joint with Stefan Bühler and Beatrix Eugster.)
2024	Scientific Exchange Grant, SNSF. Grant IZSEZ0_225960. Funding for St. Gallen Workshop on Dynamic Contracts and Learning. 10,000 CHF. (Joint with Michèle Müller-Itten.)
2018	Scientific Exchange Grant, SNSF. Grant IZSEZ0_185538. Funding for the short visit to Duke University. 4,200 CHF.
2016	Advanced Postdoc.Mobility, SNSF. Grant P300P1_167648. Funding for the visiting postdoc position at Duke University. 80,000 CHF.
2016	Johann Jakob Speiser-Scholarship. Funding for the short visit to Chapman University.

Internal Funding

2026	Basic Research Fund, University of St. Gallen. Stepping Stone Grant. CHF 22,970.
2026	Basic Research Fund, University of St. Gallen. Funding for Annual Congress of the SSES. 15,000 CHF. (Joint with Stefan Bühler and Beatrix Eugster.)
2024	Basic Research Fund, University of St. Gallen. Funding for St. Gallen Workshop on Dynamic Contracts and Learning. 15,000 CHF. (Joint with Michèle Müller-Itten.)
2023	Basic Research Fund, University of St. Gallen. Funding for hosting the Swiss Theory Day. 2,000 CHF.
2016–19	Laspeyres Fellowship, Faculty of Business and Economics, University of Basel.
2018	Forschungskredit UZH. Salary granted for a 12 month part-time postdoc position.

Awards

2024	Teaching Reduction for Excellence in Research, School of Economics and Political Science, University of St. Gallen.
2014	Faculty Prize for best PhD-Thesis, Faculty of Business and Economics, University of Basel.
2009	Best M.Sc.-Diploma in Business and Economics of the Academic Year (shared), University of Basel.
2009	Best M.Sc.-Thesis in Business and Economics of the Academic Year (shared), University of Basel.

St. Gallen, September 21, 2026